

IELTS PREPARATION MASTERCLASS

Academic vs. General Training

*A comprehensive breakdown of structure, scoring, tasks, and vital strategy
guidelines*

Selecting Your Test Version

IELTS Academic

Designed primarily for individuals planning to study or practice professionally in English-speaking environments.

- ✓ **Admissions:** Required for entry into undergraduate or postgraduate university programs.
- ✓ **Registration:** Mandatory for professional bodies (e.g., Doctors, Nurses, Engineers).

General Training

Aimed at those seeking secondary education, migration opportunities, or professional employment.

- ✓ **Migration:** Required for visas to countries like the UK, Canada, Australia, or New Zealand.
- ✓ **Work Experience:** Used by employers to verify functional everyday language competency.

Exam Structure & Timing Rules

60

TOTAL MINUTES

The Crucial Writing Blueprint

Regardless of the version, the test requires you to complete **two main tasks**, written completely by hand (no spell-check allowed!).

- ✓ **Task 1 (Shorter):** Spend ~20 minutes writing a minimum of 150 words.
- ✓ **Task 2 (Longer):** Spend ~40 minutes writing a minimum of 250 words.
- ✓ **Crucial Rule:** Task 2 is worth exactly twice as many marks as Task 1. Always prioritize Task 2 in your planning.

Academic Task 1: Visual Data

Reporting Trends Objectively

In this task, you are given a visual chart, graph, table, map, or process diagram. Your job is to describe the data in your own words.

- ✓ **Neutral Tone:** Sound like a professional reporter. Avoid giving opinions or analyzing "why" patterns occurred.
- ✓ **Core Goal:** Summarize overall trends, compare key data points, and highlight significant transitions.

 IELTS Academic visual graph analysis mockup showing trends and line charts

General Task 1: Letter Writing

Mastering Real-Life Contexts

You are given a real-life situation and must draft a formal, semi-formal, or informal letter addressing the situation.

- ✓ **Tone Matching:** If writing to a friend, use informal language. If writing to a company or manager, use professional, polite vocabulary.
- ✓ **Core Mechanics:** Ensure you clearly explain the situation, state your requests, and propose practical solutions.

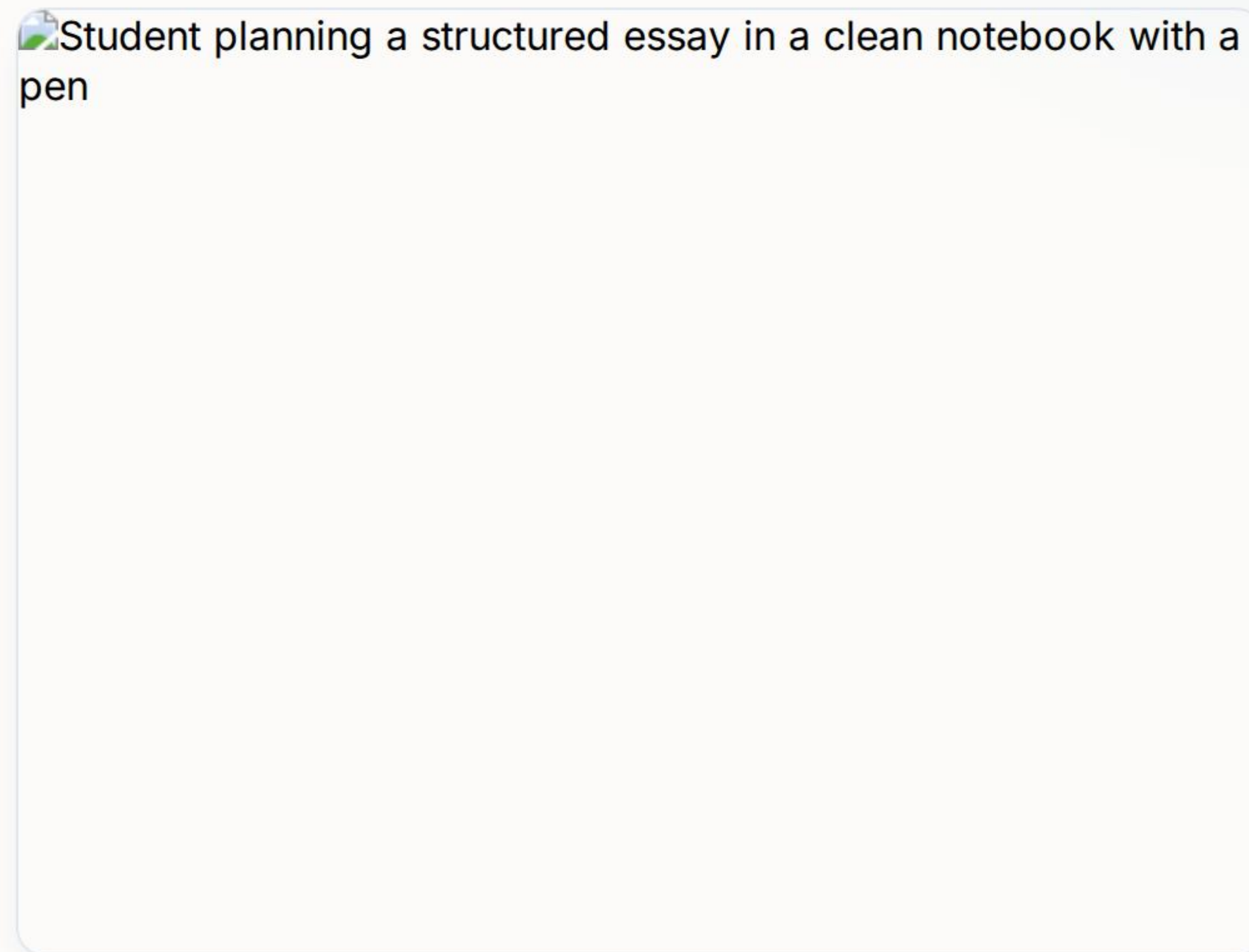
 Letter writing on desk with classic fountain pen and parchment paper

Task 2: Academic & General Essay

Constructing Logical Arguments

Both versions face an identical essay format responding to a point of view, argument, or systemic problem.

- ✓ **Topics:** General interest issues (such as health, environment, education, society, technology).
- ✓ **Objective:** Deliver a clear, structured argument. State an opinion, back it up with real-world examples, and divide points into cohesive paragraphs.



Student planning a structured essay in a clean notebook with a pen

How You Are Scored



Task Achievement

Evaluates whether you fully answered the question. For Task 1, did you report the data accurately? For Task 2, did you address all parts of the essay prompt?



Coherence & Cohesion

Measures logical organization. Are transition words (e.g., Furthermore, However, As a result) used seamlessly? Does the text split into clear paragraphs?



Lexical Resource

Scores vocabulary range. Evaluates precise word choices (e.g., "a sharp increase" vs. "an increase") and correct natural collocations.



Grammatical Range

Assesses your capacity to write error-free complex sentences, utilizing varied grammar constructs like passive voice and relative clauses.

The Critical Timing Mistake

⚠ EXAMINER WARNING

"Candidates spend too long crafting a perfect introduction, leaving themselves with insufficient time for the body paragraphs."

— MAIN CAUSE OF SCORE DROPS

Examiners care most about your **main body paragraphs** where actual arguments or trend analyses are proven. Aim to finish your introduction in **3–5 minutes** max to save time for body content.

Task 1: Academic Success Rules

▼ Data Selection

Never attempt to describe every single number. Focus entirely on:

- ✓ The absolute highest and lowest values in the datasets.
- ✓ The most obvious changes or sudden spikes in trendlines.
- ✓ Slight anomalies or periods of stability.

↕ Grouping & Synthesis

Structure your report logically for maximum coherence:

- ✓ Group similar elements or variables into separate body paragraphs.
- ✓ Write a clear overview paragraph highlighting the overall trend.
- ✓ Compare relevant groupings rather than summarizing variables in isolation.

Task 1: General Letter Rules

Tone Recognition

Your opening greeting immediately sets your Tone score.
Choose accurately:

- ✓ **Formal:** "Dear Sir/Madam," followed by a formal sign-off ("Yours faithfully,").
- ✓ **Informal:** "Dear [First Name]," with casual closings like "Warm regards," or "Best,".

Prompt Coverage

Do not omit any detail from the prompt scenario:

- ✓ Clearly detail the background situation.
- ✓ Explicitly make your request or state what you need.
- ✓ Propose a polite, practical, and constructive solution.

Task 2: Essay Success Plan

The 5-Minute Planning Rule

Before writing a word, draft a quick plan. Write down 2 or 3 core ideas and matching real-world examples. This ensures you do not get stuck or repeat arguments mid-essay.

Targeting Your Word Count

Do not waste time counting individual words. Aim for roughly 280 words (well over the 250-word minimum). If you write too little you lose marks; if too much, you run out of review time.

Preserving Check Time

Leave at least 2-3 minutes at the end. Quickly proofread to catch simple spelling slips, alignment inconsistencies, and grammatical slip-ups.

Ready to Begin?

Mastering the IELTS Writing criteria is your fastest path to achieving a high band score.

Final Action Checklist

- Determine which test version you need before beginning prep.
- Practice writing by hand on lined paper (strictly no spell-check!).
- Consistently prioritize Task 2 in your study plans.
- Use templates to streamline your Task 1 structuring.

Image Sources

A small table with two columns. The first column contains age ranges and the second column contains corresponding scores.

36-35	8
34-33	7.5
32-30	7
29-27	6.5
26-23	6
22-19	5.5
18-15	5
14-13	4.5
12-10	4
9-8	3.5

<https://ieltsliz.com/wp-content/uploads/2014/12/academic-reading-scores.jpg>

Source: ieltsliz.com



<https://www.mockupworld.co/wp-content/uploads/dynamic/2015/08/bbef3028978595.55dc564865f4e-536x0-c-default.jpg>

Source: www.mockupworld.co



<https://files-storage-l.nyc3.digitaloceanspaces.com/epic-essay/x8OUPcAXqjzv2qw5c05m4x1jh3FFJKrqmM6D3xWv.png>

Source: www.epic-essay.com